Medicaid Readiness, Legal Authority, ADLs, Activation Triggers

Eighteen words from a planning conversation, in one plain line each, and what to jot down about each.

A planning conversation has a vocabulary. Some of it belongs to the care world, some to the legal world, and some to this roadmap. These are the words you're most likely to meet, each in a plain line, with what to jot down when it comes up. Where a line carries a source number, the definition comes from that public source; the rest are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own words.

The definitions are for following the conversation. They can't tell you where Mom stands with Medicaid, and no family can work that out from a sheet like this.

Care

Long-term care

A range of services and supports a person may need to meet her personal care needs. Most of it is not medical care. [1]

WRITE DOWN The help Mom has now, if any, and who gives it.

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks of everyday life: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which of these Mom does on her own today, with the date.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Everyday tasks such as housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing meals, shopping, and using the telephone. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now.

Paying for care

Medicare

Medicare.gov says Medicare and most health insurance, including Medigap, don't pay for long-term care services, in a nursing home or in the community. [2]

WRITE DOWN What coverage Mom has, and where the cards are kept.

Medicaid

A joint federal and state program that helps people with low income and assets pay health care bills. Unlike Medicare, it does pay for custodial care in nursing homes and at home. Eligibility rules vary from state to state. [3]

WRITE DOWN What you've read or been told about it so far, and who said it.

Long-term care insurance

Insurance whose policies can vary widely: some may cover only nursing home care, others a range of services. [4]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has a policy, the company, and where the policy is kept.

Medicaid readiness

The roadmap's name for what its Assess step looks at: how a person's care needs, income, assets and paperwork stand against her state's rules. A professional who knows the state works that out.

WRITE DOWN Whether anyone has looked at this for Mom, who, and when.

Legal words

Legal authority

Permission to act on someone else's behalf. AARP's legal checklist says a family helping a parent needs it both financially and medically. [5]

WRITE DOWN Who Mom has named for money matters and for health care, if anyone.

Power of attorney

A legal document that gives someone else legal authority to make decisions about a person's money or property. [6]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has one, the date on it, and who is named.

Medical power of attorney

A document that names someone to make health care decisions for a person when she cannot. Also called a durable power of attorney for health care. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether she has one, who is named, and who holds a copy.

Advance directive

A general term for two kinds of document: a living will, and the naming of a health care surrogate or medical power of attorney. [7]

WRITE DOWN Which of the two Mom has, and where each is kept.

People

Medicaid planner

The role your Medicaid planner has in this roadmap: bringing care needs, preferences, finances, Medicaid readiness and existing legal planning into one picture, and helping a family separate what can be addressed now from what should be monitored.

WRITE DOWN Your open questions, and which ones you think belong here.

Elder law attorney

An attorney who deals daily with the issues surrounding old age. The work can include powers of attorney, advance directives, wills, and exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid. [8]

WRITE DOWN The legal questions on your list, and the documents you'd bring.

Licensed financial or insurance professional

The people who review investment and insurance questions. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau notes that many professionals must be licensed or registered by a government agency, and suggests checking qualifications before hiring one. [9]

WRITE DOWN The money and insurance questions on your list.

Geriatric care manager

Usually a licensed nurse, social worker or therapist trained in caring for older adults, who evaluates care needs and recommends services. Also called an eldercare consultant or an aging life care manager. [10]

WRITE DOWN Whether one has seen Mom, and what they noted.

The plan itself

Monitoring

The roadmap's word for what a family keeps an eye on without acting on it: changes in Mom's health, in the help she gets, and in what care costs.

WRITE DOWN What you're already keeping an eye on, even informally.

Activation trigger

An event a family has agreed would mean it's time to open the plan again, such as a hospital stay or a new diagnosis. Which events go on the list is worked out with your Medicaid planner.

WRITE DOWN The events your family has mentioned so far, in your own words.

Professional review

A look at one part of the picture by the professional it belongs to, before anything in that part is changed.

WRITE DOWN Which parts have been looked at, by whom, and when.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't state any limit or rule, say which of these words apply to Mom, or say whether she would qualify for anything. Rules vary by state, and a professional who knows yours is the one to ask. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You can follow a planning conversation now. The planning interview asks about your family's situation in plain language and gives you a free planning report you can bring to that conversation.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Terms with a source number are defined from that public source. Medicaid readiness, Medicaid planner, monitoring, activation trigger and professional review are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own words. What to jot down is ours.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Long-term care
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
4. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
5. AARP, A Legal Checklist for Family Caregivers
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options
7. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Legal Steps for Medical Well-being
8. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?
9. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else’s money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
10. AARP, Geriatric Care Managers Advocate for Older Adults — and Their Caregivers